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WEDNESDAY, NOVEMBER 11, 2026

Kraft Group seeks large data center in Sutton

Residents pack intense Select Board hearing

By Aaron Pressman and Travis Andersen
GLOBE STAFF

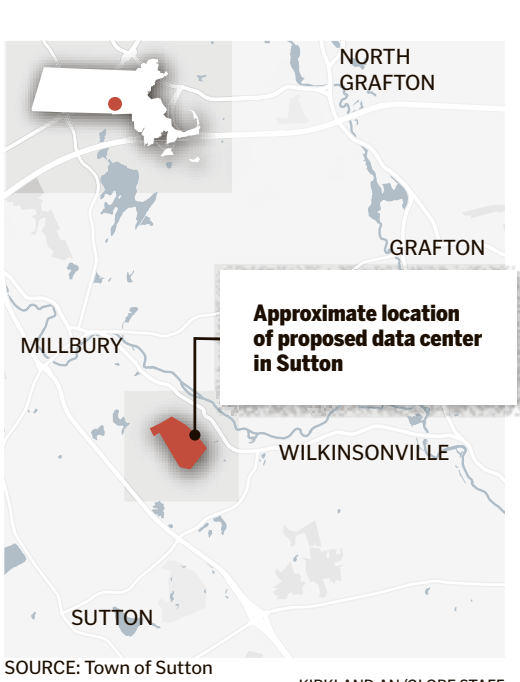
New England Patriots owner Robert Kraft's company is stepping into a political minefield, proposing to build one of the largest data centers in the country in the Central Massachusetts town of Sutton, just as opposition to the facilities is intensifying.

In this area, known for its farmland and home to about 9,700 residents, the Kraft Group would build a massive, $16 billion data center campus. The project would include 10 buildings, erected on land owned by the Krafts' Unified Packaging box business about 10 miles south of Worcester. It would push Massachusetts into the world of big data centers, as the fourth-biggest facility in the United States, according to the research firm Cleanview.

The proposal must be approved by multiple town committees before moving ahead, and it puts Kraft once again at the center of political controversy, this time as data centers have become political poison across the country. Voters last week from Maine to California approved 44 referendums to block or slow data center construction. Last month, the Western Massachusetts community of Westfield moved to block a large data center proposed there.

The Sutton Select Board met Tuesday night

DATA CENTER, Page A7



SOURCE: Town of Sutton

KIRKLAND AN/GLOBE STAFF

A third rail on the drive to state titles for high schools

Boys in field hockey still a touchy subject

DAN SHAUGHNESSY

SOMERSET — The Somerset Berkley Regional high school field hockey team beat Doherty, 5-0, Monday at Hanson Memorial Stadium. The Blue Raiders advanced to the quarterfinals of the Massachusetts Division 2 championship and will play Hingham in a quarterfinal at Hanson on Saturday afternoon.

Somerset's best player is senior Ryan Crook, the son of longtime Somerset field hockey coach Jen Crook. Lucas Crook, Jen Crook's oldest son, helped the Raiders win state championships along with sister Cami in 2018 and '19. Now Ryan — South Coast Conference MVP each of the last two seasons — is going for a third straight state title.

Coach Crook's Blue Raiders outshot Doherty, 17-0, Monday and sisters Emma and Olivia Cormier combined for three goals in the rout. Ryan Crook had an assist and a late-game goal on a spectacular Orr-esque rush from midfield, giving him 201 career points. Somerset's senior boy was faster than most of the girls and a superior stickhandler, but did not injure or knock any girls over in a chippy game that saw the Worcester

SHAUGHNESSY, Page C7

Farwell guilty of murder

Former officer faces mandatory life sentence in death of Birchmore



BARRY CHIN/GLOBE STAFF

Barbara Wright (left), cousin of Sandra Birchmore, was emotional at the federal courthouse after Matthew Farwell was found guilty.

By Laura Crimaldi and Sean Cotter
GLOBE STAFF

Former Stoughton police detective Matthew Farwell was found guilty Tuesday of killing Sandra Birchmore and the unborn child she was carrying, ending a tortuous case of alleged sexual exploitation, police wrongdoing, and a coverup that finally made its way to a brutal, monthlong federal trial.

Farwell, 41, faces an automatic life sentence for two convictions: killing the 23-year-old Birchmore and causing the death of the fetus. He will remain in federal custody through his sentencing, which is set for Feb. 3.

"Today, justice was served for Ms. Sandra Birchmore and her unborn son," US Attorney Leah B. Foley said in a press conference shortly after the decision.

The federal prosecutors said Farwell strangled Birchmore to death Feb. 1, 2021, and staged her apartment to look like she had hanged herself. He did so, the prosecutors told the jury, to hide evidence of past wrongdoing, including that he sexually exploited Birchmore when she was underage.

"He needed to silence Sandra," Foley said, and, "he silenced Sandra by murdering her."

Birchmore's cousin Ray Cosgrove, representing her family at the press conference, focused on his relative, and the family's loss.

"Sandra mattered before anyone outside her family knew her name," Cosgrove said. "Her life still continues to matter today."

Farwell's attorneys argued that Birchmore, who had a history of mental-health issues, died by suicide that night after Farwell ended their relationship.

After deliberating for more than 15 hours over three days — and at one point reporting a temporary deadlock — the jurors ultimately agreed with the prosecu-

FARWELL, Page A10

Health premiums climb 38% since '19

Rates in Mass., among top in US, outpace inflation

By Jonathan Saltzman
GLOBE STAFF

Health insurance premiums for families in Massachusetts climbed 38 percent from 2019 to 2025 — considerably outpacing the rest of the country — and will hit $50,000 a year by 2032 at recent growth rates, according to a state report released Tuesday.

At a time when millions of Americans are worried about affordability, the study by the Massachusetts Health Policy Commission found that premiums had risen faster in the state than household income and inflation.

The average family premium for employer-based coverage reached nearly $30,000 last year. The figure, which includes employer and employee contributions, is among the highest in the country, due to the surge in use of pricey antiobesity drugs, the prevalence of more expensive imaging tests, and other factors, the commission said.

Nationally, premiums rose 28 percent from 2019 to 2025, led by gains in Nebraska, Oregon, and New Hampshire, ac-

PREMIUMS, Page A7

'That felt completely unfair and just deeply weird.'

REN DOMINGUEZ, *an early education teacher, on the closure notice of her school*

Closure of child care site opens divisions at Smith College

By Brooke Hauser
GLOBE STAFF

NORTHAMPTON — Candice Price, an associate professor of mathematical sciences at Smith College, hadn't planned on talking to her students about her child care struggles.

But last month when the women's college abruptly announced it would be closing its child care center in June, she saw a teachable moment in her feminist mathematics class.

Instead of hiding her panic about finding care for her almost 3-year-old son, Xavier, Price leaned into it during a lesson on the gender pay gap, which widens after a woman has her first child.

"I'm trying my best," said Price, a single mom who also cares for a disabled parent. It's basic math, really: The more time she has to spend trying to secure child care, the less time she can give to her students.

Like many of her colleagues, Price was blindsided by Smith's decision to close its century-old Center for Early Childhood Education at Fort Hill, which serves about 80 children from the broader community, but prioritizes and offers discounts to employees.

Public pushback has since forced administrators to keep Fort Hill open

CHILD CARE, Page A10

You can travel around a culinary world on one Peterborough block of Fenway as restaurants offer a swirl of aromas and a taste of eight cuisines. **G1.**

In their first matchup against the Philadelphia 76ers and former Boston star Jaylen Brown, the Celtics prevailed, 123-101, led by Paul George's 36 points. **C1.**

New England scientists and advocates attending climate talks in Turkey say Democratic victories in the midterms have created a sense of possibility. **B1.**

RELOCATED, RESTORED, REMEMBERED

Each week, Gene Theroux tends to gravestones of veterans and their families at Quabbin Park Cemetery in Ware. "Behind every person on these stones is a story," he said. "Part of what I do is being a voice for the Valley." Before the Quabbin Reservoir was filled, 7,613 graves were moved from 34 cemeteries in towns that no longer exist. **B1.**



MELECK ELDAHSHOURY FOR THE BOSTON GLOBE

The danks are coming

Wednesday: Cloud-sun mix. High 54-59, low 44-49.

Thursday: Possible nor'easter. High 51-56, low 43-48.

Sunrise: 6:30. Sunset: 4:26.

Weather and comics, **G6-7.**

Obituaries, **C9.**

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